



What We Mean by Protecting Them

Student copy (project or hand out)

1 Start where almost everyone already stands. A child is not a small adult, and the people who raise children owe them some shelter from what they are not ready to carry. No serious person disputes that some material belongs to a later year, that a parent may reasonably want a say in what a nine-year-old meets on a library shelf, that protection is a real duty and not a pretext invented to control. Grant all of it. The argument that follows does not need to take any of it back.

2 It needs only to ask what, precisely, the protecting is protecting from. [[1]]There is a kind of harm a child can suffer from a book, and there is the discomfort a child, or more often an adult, feels at encountering a life unlike their own; these are not the same thing, and the whole question turns on whether we keep them apart. [[2]] The shared premise was that children deserve protection from harm. It was never that children deserve protection from difference. If the premise is the first, the conclusion arrives uninvited.

3 Look at what is actually being pulled. [[3]]And Tango Makes Three is a picture book about two male penguins who raise a chick together; it contains nothing a censor could honestly call obscene, and it has been among the most challenged books in the country. [[4]] The stated reason for removal in 2025 was, repeatedly, the protection of minors from illegal obscenity, alongside objections to LGBTQIA+ characters and to coverage of race and racism. When the obscenity charge is leveled at a book whose offense is two penguins, the charge is doing other work. Of 4,235 titles challenged last year, 1,671, about forty percent, told the stories of LGBTQIA+ people and people of color.

4 There is a second tell, in who is doing the challenging. The romantic picture is a worried parent at a board meeting. The record from the American Library Association says otherwise: in 2025, ninety-two percent of challenges came from pressure groups and government officials, up from seventy-two the year before, and fewer than three percent from individual parents. [[5]]The three most challenged titles, for what it is worth, were Sold, The Perks of Being a Wallflower, and Gender Queer. [[6]] A duty that began in one household has been handed to organized campaigns, and 5,668 books were pulled from libraries on its authority.

5 So the shared premise, followed honestly, lands somewhere the premise-holder did not mean to go. Protection from harm is a duty. Protection from the existence of other people is something else, and the cost of it is not borne by the adults who feel safer. It is borne by the child who never finds the one book that said her life was possible, and by every child, hers included, who grows up having practiced the narrow habit of mistaking unfamiliarity for danger. That habit does not stay in the library. We were trying to keep them safe. It is worth wondering what we taught them instead.

AP-style multiple choice:

1. In the third paragraph, the writer introduces *And Tango Makes Three* primarily in order to
 - A) argue that all obscenity objections to library books are made in bad faith
 - B) expose a gap between the stated rationale for removal and the books actually being targeted
 - C) praise the literary quality of a book that has been unfairly removed
 - D) establish that picture books are more frequently challenged than other genres
2. In context, the closing sentences ('We were trying to keep them safe. It is worth wondering what we taught them instead.') best convey which of the following about the writer's tone?
 - A) triumphant, having decisively won the argument against the other side
 - B) restrained and rueful, declining to accuse while letting the consequence settle on the reader
 - C) neutral and detached, reporting the outcome without any evaluative stance
 - D) indignant and accusatory, condemning parents for deliberate cruelty

Discussion questions:

1. The writer concedes at the outset that protecting children is a genuine duty, then argues the duty is being misapplied. Does granting that opening ground make the later argument more persuasive, or does it concede too much? Point to specific sentences.
2. The piece distinguishes 'protection from harm' from 'protection from difference.' Is that distinction always clear in practice, or are there real cases where the two are hard to separate? Where might a thoughtful parent and the writer genuinely disagree?

Writing prompt (Homework or extended in-class, Q3 argument):

The opener argues that protecting children from genuine harm and shielding them from the existence of people unlike themselves are different acts, and that confusing the two carries a long-term cost. Write an essay that argues a position on the following claim: Adults charged with the welfare of children have a duty to expose them to perspectives and lives different from their own, even when that exposure makes the adults uncomfortable. In your response you should develop your argument with specific evidence and reasoning, examine the strongest version of the opposing view, and qualify your position where the evidence calls for it. You may draw on your reading, observation, knowledge, or experience; you are not required to use the facts in the opener.